SPARKY'S SCIENCE FACTS

What Are the Planets?

Astronomy · Ages 7+

> **Short answer:** Eight planets travel around our Sun. In order from the Sun they are Mercury, Venus, Earth, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus and Neptune.

How it works

- The Sun is a star. It is not a planet, and it gives the planets light and heat.
- The four closest planets are small and rocky. The four far ones are giant balls of gas and ice.
- Jupiter is the biggest planet. Mercury is the smallest and closest to the Sun.
- Venus is the hottest planet, even though Mercury is closer, because its thick clouds trap heat.
- Earth is the only planet we know of with living things.

Key words: Orbit: the path around the Sun; Dwarf planet: a small world like Pluto

Common mix-ups

- Pluto is not a planet any more: since 2006 it is called a dwarf planet.
- Stars twinkle; planets usually shine with a steady light.

Did you know? SALT, one of the biggest telescopes in the southern half of the world, is near Sutherland in the Northern Cape, where the night sky is very dark.

Try it: Remember the order with: My Very Eager Mother Just Served Us Nachos.

Ask Sparky: Which planet has rings? Could people live on Mars?